Rising electric car sales complicate auto industry plea for emissions leniency

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【要点】

・欧州の自動車メーカーが電気自動車（EV）の販売が好調であることを報告しており、排出削減目標の柔軟性を求める業界の主張を弱める結果となっている。

・ルノーは欧州でのEV販売が前年比85%増、フォルクスワーゲンのEV受注が39%増など、主要メーカーで大幅な販売増を記録している。

・EU域内のEV市場シェアは2026年前9ヶ月で22.7%に達し、自動車産業は排出削減目標への柔軟性を求めているが、批評家はこれ以上の譲歩は電動化への世界的な転換を遅延させるだけだと主張している。

・欧州委員会と加盟国の政治家が2035年までの排出削減目標を巡り協議中であり、無条件90%削減と一部のオフセット要件付き87.5%削減など複数の案が検討されている。

・自動車メーカーはEVの利益率がまだ低く、特にバッテリーコストが高いため、設定された期限内に利益を上げて目標を達成できるかどうか不確実であると主張している。

【メール原文】

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By Jordyn Dahl · Oct 29, 2026, 7:24 PM · View in your browser

Europe’s automakers report booming electric vehicle sales and orders this week, seemingly undercutting their case for more flexibility in meeting emission reduction targets.

French brand Renault saw its EV sales jump 85% year-over-year in Europe in the third quarter. Germany’s flagship carmaker Volkswagen told investors its European EV orders climbed 39% in the first nine months of this year. Mercedes-Benz and Stellantis also revealed a sharp increase in EV sales.

In the first nine months of 2026, EVs accounted for a 22.7% share of the EU market, up from 16.1% a year earlier, making them the second most popular powertrain choice year-to-date, according to data from the car lobby ACEA.

The surge comes as the EU’s institutions near the finish line in negotiating emission reduction targets for automakers.

The industry and conservative political parties staunchly maintain that the EU must give more flexibility to companies to meet the targets so they can avoid cutting jobs and retain overall competitiveness. Critics argue any more flexibility will only put the automakers further behind in the global transition to

EVs.

At stake is job security for hundreds of thousands of workers and the fate of an industry responsible for more than 7% of the EU's GDP.

The European Commission proposed its Automotive Package in December of last year that included a reform of its de facto 2035 combustion engine ban. It proposed lowering the target from a 100% reduction from 2021 levels to 90%, provided automakers offset the extra CO2 with investments in alternative fuels and green steel.

A recently inked French-German compromise would lower the target to an unconditional 90%, while a centrist coalition in the European Parliament is poised to pass an agreement that would set the target at 87.5%, with 5% given unconditionally and 7.5% required to be offset with green steel investments.

EU car lobby, ACEA, has advocated for an unconditional 90% target, with additional flexibility granted for investments in low-carbon materials beyond just steel.

While sales gains strengthen the case that European consumers are moving toward EVs, they don't settle whether automakers can meet the EU's timetable profitably, or whether more time would protect jobs, the industry argues.

A delicate balance

Automakers say margins on electric vehicles are still too narrow to turn a profit, especially on batteries, the most expensive component of an EV.

Volkswagen, for example, told investors on Thursday during its earnings call that it doesn't expect its EVs to have margin parity with the combustion engine counterparts until at least 2030.

Decades of producing combustion-engine vehicles have created a well-oiled machine with low costs and high profits that helped finance higher salaries and benefits for European workers.

Those days are over, though, thanks to plummeting sales in China . Volkswagen has implemented a cost-cutting plan that will cull 100,000 jobs and potentially shutter four factories. Mercedes told investors this week it will conduct a second round of buyouts after its Chinese sales plummeted 31% year-over-year in the third quarter, far more than the luxury brand expected.

A new study from the International Council on Clean Transportation found that up to 185,000 European automotive jobs could be lost if the emission reduction targets are delayed. In that scenario, jobs focused on combustion-engine vehicle production would be temporarily saved, but fewer roles would be created in the charging industry or in battery production, the group says .

But developing new technologies and converting plants to manufacture EVs instead comes at a steep price. Volkswagen says EV sales are ramping up faster than their costs are coming down, while Renault and Stellantis are pressing Brussels for more flexibility on emissions rules to reduce costs.

The proposed flexibilities are insufficient, Renault's chief financial officer Duncan Minto said on an earnings call Thursday, adding "the negotiation process probably doesn't take into account the reality of the European industrial ecosystem today."

Other issues are also driving up costs, making it harder for automakers to pay more to meet the targets.

“We face tariffs, a sharply contracting Chinese market and intense competition in Europe from new Chinese entrants. The market success of our electric cars also weighs on our margins in the short term,” Arno Antlitz, VW’s chief operating and financial officer, told investors.

Growing demand

The war in Iran and rising gas prices have helped create more consumer interest in EVs, along with various government subsidies for those who make the transition.

But the companies contend that while demand is increasing, consumers aren’t switching to electric vehicles fast enough to meet the EU’s emission targets, which they say would force them to pay billions in fines for noncompliance at a time when costs are mounting.

This week’s numbers, however, make that a difficult argument to maintain.

Mercedes reported its EV sales increased 78% year-over-year in the third quarter, with every third car sold by the German brand in Europe an electric model. French-Italian-American brand Stellantis said its European EV sales increased 65% year-over-year.

These numbers don’t tell the full story, according to Ferdinand Dudenhöffer, a former automotive executive and founder of Germany’s private Center for Automotive Research.

Electric vehicles take twice as long to be delivered to customers as internal combustion engine models, meaning the figures reported this week are lower than the actual number of sales, Dudenhöffer said, attributing the delay to production bottlenecks like a lack of batteries.

European automakers aren’t the only ones benefiting from demand. Chinese incumbents — facing overcapacity at home and effectively blocked from the U.S. market — are targeting European customers .

China is expected to export more than 800,000 hybrid vehicles to the EU this year, prompting the Commission to negotiate a tentative deal with Beijing that will cap the number of vehicles imported each year.

The deal could “give a small relief” to Europe’s automakers, Antlitz told investors, but “we expect the competitive pressure to stay.”

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